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A timeline of Kryptonians on screen



1948

Superman (Serial)

The first live-action appearance of Krypton's last son introduced audiences to Superman on screen.



1978

Superman: The Movie

Christopher Reeve's Superman made Krypton iconic, complete with Marlon Brando's Jor-El.



1984

Supergirl

Helen Slater's Supergirl gave Kara Zor-El her first big-screen solo adventure.



1988

Superboy

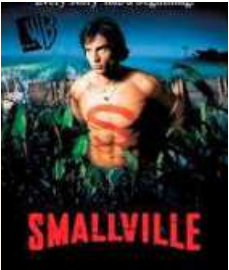
Television expanded Kryptonian lore through Clark Kent's early years in Smallville.



1996

Superman: The Animated Series

The acclaimed series redefined Krypton's aesthetics and mythology for a new generation.



2001

Smallville

The long-running show deeply explored Kryptonian heritage and prophecy.



2006

Superman Returns

Brandon Routh revived the Man of Steel, continuing the legacy of the classic films while bringing Krypton back to theaters after nearly two decades.



2013

Man of Steel

Zack Snyder reinvented Krypton as an advanced alien civilisation and introduced Henry Cavill's brooding hero to the world.

2015

Supergirl (TV Series)

Melissa Benoist's Kara Danvers brought Supergirl to television for six seasons.



2022

DC League of Super-Pets

Krypto the Superdog became the latest beloved Kryptonian to reach the big screen.



2023

The Flash

Sasha Calle debuted as Supergirl, marking the character's cinematic return after nearly 40 years.

2023

My Adventures with Superman

The animated series reimaged Clark Kent, Lois Lane and Jimmy Olsen for a new generation.

2025

Superman

The new DC Universe introduced David Corenswet's Superman and teased Milly Alcock's Supergirl.



2026

Supergirl: Woman of Tomorrow

Kara Zor-El finally receives a new solo film, adapting Tom King and Bilquis Evely's acclaimed comic.



Having inherited the House of El, Milly Alcock and Eve Ridley discuss Kryptonian legacy, flawed heroes and why Kara Zor-El may be DC's true punk rocker

Cape against the machine

Ayaan Paul Chowdhury

Australian actor Milly Alcock will soon be stepping into one of the oldest lineages in blockbuster cinema. The story of Krypton on screen reaches back almost half a century to Richard Donner's *Superman* in 1978, the film that turned Christopher Reeve's version of Kal-El (the Kryptonian birth name of Superman) into the defining modern superhero, and established the cultural imagination of "truth, justice, and the American Way" that Hollywood has spent decades either preserving or interrogating. Since then, the House of El has passed through successive generations, from Helen Slater's *Supergirl* in 1984 and Tom Welling's television-era Clark Kent in *Smallville*; to Henry Cavill's brooding alien in Zack Snyder's DC Extended Universe and now, David Corenswet's earnest reinvention in James Gunn's 2025 *Superman* – every actor who puts on the crest carries the accumulated expectations about what a Kryptonian hero ought to represent.

Milly is acutely aware of that history, and her understanding of legacy appears rooted in a sense of stewardship. Asked about joining that tradition, she says, "I think that it's such a privilege to be a part of a long legacy of such beloved actors and characters. In this reiteration, she is such a different version of Supergirl than we've seen in the past and that has made the privilege even more exciting."

The new DC Universe under DC Studios heads James Gunn and Peter Safran has been designed around reinvention, with *Supergirl* serving as the second feature in the franchise's Chapter One: *Gods and Monsters* slate after the commercial success of *Superman* in 2025. The film, directed by Craig Gillespie and written by Ana Nogueira, adapts Tom King and Bilquis Evely's acclaimed 2021-22 comic series *Supergirl: Woman of Tomorrow*, a spacefaring revenge narrative that follows Kal-El's cousin Kara Zor-El, beyond the familiar setting of Earth-bound stories.

Though Supergirl boasts



(Clockwise from above) Milly Alcock in and as *Supergirl*. WARNER BROS

the same crest, draws from the same solar battery, and traces her origins to the same dead planet as Superman, the cultural history of Krypton on screen has overwhelmingly been organised around men. Across nearly five decades of film and television, the defining Kryptonian figures have largely involved the consummation of male saviours bearing impossible expectations. But Kara's entry to that lineage is shaped by different circumstances, because DC's current continuity presents her as someone who spent her childhood on a surviving fragment of Krypton, having witnessed death on a planetary scale and arriving on Earth with trauma that Clark Kent never possessed. Those experiences are central to the character's construction and explain why her relationship with heroism doesn't stem from some uncomplicated altruism.

Kara's defining trait, at least in Alcock's telling, emerges from the fact that her flaws are neither concealed nor conquered. "I am just so obsessed with Kara," she says. "I think that regardless of gender or age, all audiences will be able to see themselves within her. I think that her being a woman also adds to those exceeding expectations, but I think the most important aspect of her being able to exceed people's expectations is her reluctance to be a hero

and her absolute kind of solace within her flaws, and that becomes kind of the best quality about her."

Meanwhile, 14-year-old Eve Ridley plays Ruthye Marye Knoll, the young alien girl whose quest for vengeance across the galaxy alongside Kara drives much of the story. In the original comic, Ruthye was both narrator and witness to Kara's actions, making her our entry point into the story through the eyes of someone still learning what a 'hero' means. Ridley's own understanding of superheroes appears to have undergone a similar transformation during production. "My view on superheroes was very stereotypical", she says. "They are strong. They are pretty. They are perfect. And that's how I grew up, that's the idea I had. But coming into [*Supergirl*], I now have a completely different view on superheroes. Kara is not perfect at all, and I think that really shows, especially the younger generation, that you can be yourself."

Sometimes that can make you your own hero. So now, I look at superheroes a lot differently."

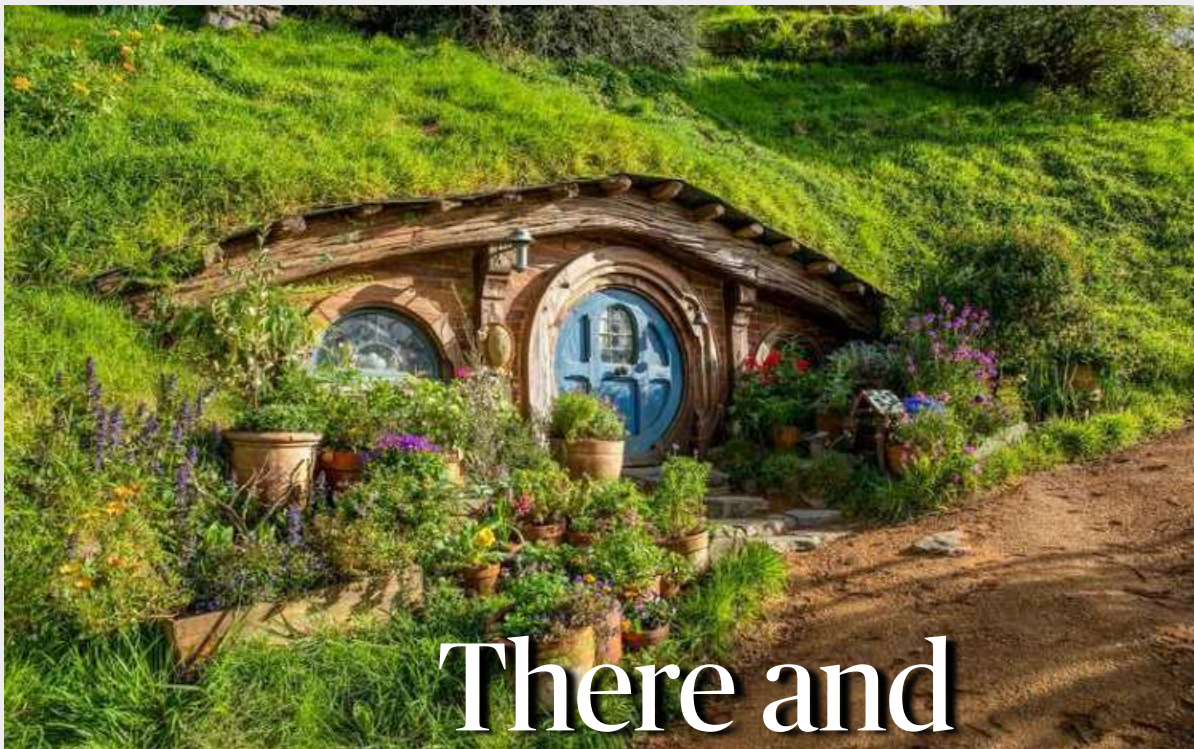
The cultural recalibration helps explain why David Corenswet's Superman acquired an unexpectedly "punk-rock" reputation after the release of Gunn's 2025 film, as audiences seemed to embrace Clark Kent's refusal to meet cynicism with cynicism as a genuinely subversive act (though that reading owed something to Gunn's own sonic choices, including the particularly on-the-nose Swedish punk outfit Teddybears' soon viral "Punkrocker").

Milly is entirely convinced that Kara may have a stronger claim to that title. Asked whether Supergirl embodies the spirit even more fully than her Kryptonian cousin, she chuckles, "Yeah, definitely. I'm sorry, Clark, but I think I beat you on this one." After all, what could be more punk than inheriting the most recognisable symbol in fiction while remaining fundamentally unconvinced by the mythology built around it? *Woman of Tomorrow* has often been described as a cosmic riff on *True Grit*, and Kara often has the air of a reluctant feminist icon in the mould of Ellen Ripley, with just enough Joan Jett in her DNA to suggest she doesn't "give a damn 'bout my bad reputation". Though she may wear the same crest as DC's incorruptible American optimist, her's is a story shaped by more lived accounts of mass death and exile (and heaven knows she's miserable now).

Milly's playlist during production may also explain why this iteration of Supergirl already feels a little scuffed around the edges in the best possible way. She cites the Australian punk group Amyl and the Sniffers, Irish post-punk sensations Fontaines D.C., and old reliable Radiohead as frequent companions during filming.

For those of us who watched her breakout turn as the young Rhaenyra Targaryen chafe against prophecy, patriarchy, and succession in HBO's *House of the Dragon*, it feels fitting to witness that instinct for insubordination find a new vessel in Kara – call it teenage kicks, if you will.

Supergirl hits theatres on June 26.



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For both JRR Tolkien’s seminal high fantasy novels and Peter Jackson’s Oscar-winning adaptations, The Shire is where it all began. When Jackson went looking for it in 1998, the place needed to feel untouched by time, which is how a helicopter survey over Waikato landed his team on the Alexander family’s sheep farm – a 1,250-acre spread near Matamata. Legend has it that location scout David Comer, dropped in unannounced and interrupted an important rugby match to pitch a fantasy film to the owner, Ian Alexander, and somehow that conversation led to nine months of construction beginning in 1999. The New Zealand Army was drafted in to cut roads and move earth while crews built Hobbit-hole façades into the hills and planted gardens. When filming wrapped, the set was meant to disappear, but weather stalled the teardown and those leftover fragments nudged the site into public tours by 2002, and eventually into a full rebuild when Jackson returned for *The Hobbit* film trilogy; this time using permanent materials and obsessive

There and back again

The iconic Hobbiton Movie Set – built on a 1,250-acre Waikato farm discovered by Peter Jackson in 1998 – turns a lifelong memory of the Shire into an unforgettable adventure

detail so nothing would need to be faked again. Hobbiton now sits a couple of hours from Auckland, as one of New Zealand’s most sought-after experiences that thousands travel across the world to visit, every year.

At Hobbiton, everyone gathers at the Shire’s Rest before being loaded onto green buses that cover the short drive to the set. The landscape outside already looks like

it has been graded for a film, blue sky held steady over clean rolling hills with sheep scattered across in clustered specks of white. A screen at the front flicks on and Peter Jackson appears to introduce the site.

Our little fellowship steps off at a small entrance marked by a wooden Hobbiton sign, and our guide Paul gathers us with a quick question about who had seen the



(Clockwise from left) Glimpses from a tour at Hobbiton, New Zealand. AYAAN PAUL CHOWDHURY AND TOURISM NEW ZEALAND



films. Though a few hesitate, he shrugs it off with the assurance that plenty of people arrive with no context and still leave thoroughly satisfied. He leads us down a narrow path which was the exact route where Gandalf enters the Shire and where Frodo meets him on that slight incline, arms folded; Paul pauses to let us complete the line, “You’re late”.

The Shire sprawled before me in all its glory, a wooden signpost beside a tended garden pointing to East Farthing, West Farthing, and Tuckborough. Hobbit Holes cut into the hills on either side with colourful round doors. The ground rose in a series of ascending terraces so more dwellings appeared as my eye moved upward, until it reached the hilltop where Bag End overlooks the rest. In total, Hobbiton features 44 Hobbit Holes across 12 acres of the

Alexander farm, and each dwelling tries to live up to Tolkien’s original vision for the Shire-folk from *The Hobbit*.

Every hole is cut into the hillside with round doors, deep-set windows, and garden frontage. The structure of Hobbiton draws heavily from the rural English Midlands Tolkien grew up in, particularly Worcestershire and Warwickshire, and that influence carries through in how the Shire is organised into old county divisions called Farthings.

We wind our way upward along the same contours the camera traces towards Bag End, set above everything else with a clear line of sight across the village. Bilbo’s round green door is framed by a simple fence plastered with the iconic sign that reads “No admittance except on party

business”. The frontage is littered with details that map directly onto the opening stretch of *Fellowship of the Ring* where Gandalf and Bilbo pass time with Old Toby while trading old stories and blowing smoke ships through smoke rings.

The path leads back down into the centre of the Shire where the ground opens into a wide clearing used for gatherings, with a tall maypole set to one side wrapped in long ribbons that are still used during events at Hobbiton, and opposite it stands the Party Tree, a towering Monterey pine positioned beside the lake, identified during the original location scouting as the natural centrepiece for Bilbo’s “eleventy-first birthday”.

As the walk reaches its final stretch, the focus narrows toward Bagshot Row, and at the centre of that cluster we find an unmistakable yellow door framed by pretty climbing roses that spill over the entrance. Paul recalls the closing moments of *The Return of the King*, where good ‘ol Samwise Gamgee returns with Rosie Cotton and their children, steps inside, and shuts the door on the entire Middle Earth journey.

Everything around the place is scaled to Hobbit proportions and open to touch and interaction.

We stepped back out through the rear door and the path took us past the working mill and across the small bridge toward the last stop, the Green Dragon Inn. Inside, the tavern is held up by large timber beams, and features uneven floors, heavy wooden tables, a fireplace, and walls lined with tankards and small details that suggest years of use.

Paul reminds us a choice of the house brews made exclusively for this place is included in the tour, and I go straight for the stout. Leaving the Shire really put Bilbo and Frodo’s choices into perspective since leaving something this beautiful always seems to cost you a little part of yourself.

All I’m left with now is the bittersweet melancholia that it was real, it happened, that I went there and came back again.

The writer was in New Zealand at the invitation of Tourism New Zealand

As overtourism swells across Europe in summer, more travellers are opting for the shoulder season, drawn by quieter streets, shorter queues, lower hotel rates and a slower pace of life

Europe, uncrowded

Rahul Sachitanand

For years, Indians have followed a familiar pattern when planning European holidays. Their travel to Europe is largely concentrated between May and September, with demand peaking during the May-June school-holiday window and continuing through the European summer months of July and August.

Travellers are also rethinking their holiday plans, as unrest in the Persian Gulf and subsequent restrictions make travel to this region challenging and connections to North America costlier. Airlines too have shifted their focus, with carriers such as Germany’s Lufthansa adding more flights to Europe.

In 2019, Europe recorded an estimated 270 million international tourist arrivals during the core July-August period; by summer 2025, that figure exceeded 300 million. Cities and islands, including Barcelona, Venice, Santorini, Amsterdam, and parts of coastal Spain are now dealing with soaring summer visitor numbers.

Between April and June and September and October, with fewer tourists, you stand a better chance to book hotels at cheaper rates and witness shorter queues at ticket counters and popular destinations.

Mallorca unhurried
Mallorca, one of Spain’s Balearic Islands in the Mediterranean, is one

of the best places to experience this difference. The journey begins in Europe’s big-city hubs: Frankfurt’s steel-and-concrete rhythm, Amsterdam’s endless terminals, the sprawling airports of Paris. Around 2.5-3 hours later, you descend into Palma, flying over sandstone, sunburnt terraces and sea-soaked promenades. I land there in December, when the island is far less crowded than during the summer months, when tourists make a beeline for it.

In Palma de Mallorca, the capital and largest city of the Balearic Islands, we walk into Japo Santa Catalina, a Japanese-fusion restaurant, without a dinner reservation and find a table immediately. Outside, the streets are lively but not crowded. Locals move between cafés and bars, taking their time over drinks. The relaxed, almost village-like pace is a big contrast to the island’s busy summer reputation.

In July last year, over 25 lakh tourists visited, even though only about 9.2 lakh people live there year-round. Each year, the island welcomes around 1.4 crore visitors. During peak season, tourists outnumber locals by more than 14 to one, and the island’s services struggles to keep up. Locals say that in the busiest weeks, visitors spend just seven minutes at cafés and restaurants before moving on.

But outside the peak months, Mallorca feels completely different. In central Palma de Mallorca, Can Joan de s’Aigo, which dates back around 1700 (it moved to its current



(Clockwise from left) Cathedral of Santa Maria; wooden tram in Soller; church of Eulalia in Mallorca; Torrent de Sa Riera canal in Mallorca. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK AND BHAVNA SATYANARAYAN



location in 1977, after the old building deteriorated) the historic bakery gives us a glimpse of this slower rhythm. It is famous for ensaimada, the spiral-shaped pastry, dusted with powdered sugar and filled with cream, pumpkin jam or chocolate. Inside the bakery, the mood is unhurried, with locals chatting over coffee rather than tourists rushing through tightly packed itineraries.

Paired with a thick, decadent hot chocolate, the ensaimada makes for an indulgent afternoon break. What lingers most is the relaxed pace of the room. We order a coca

de patata next, a soft, slightly sweet bun that’s especially popular with coffee or hot chocolate, and cuarto, an airy sponge cake traditionally eaten dipped into thick chocolate or ice cream, before looking around Palma’s imposing La Seu Cathedral and Palau de l’Almudaina, the old Moorish fortress-turned-royal palace.

Beyond Palma
As we travel further into Mallorca, the pace is even slower. A short 45-minute drive from Palma takes us to Söller, 30 kilometres away, a town set between the

mountains and the sea. Its famous wooden tram runs from the main square to the harbour, taking half an hour to cover the five-kilometre distance. In summer, lines for the tram often stretch down the street as people wait to board.

Off-season, we settle into a leisurely journey past citrus groves, flowering plants and sun-warmed stone houses before reaching the harbour. Some beach bars remain closed, but enough cafés and restaurants stay open.

Further North is the town of Pollença, about 60 kilometres from Palma. Its most famous spot is the

Calvari staircase, a steep set of 365 stone steps leading up to a small chapel. In summer, tourists climb the steps for sweeping views of the hills. But when we visit, the climb feels peaceful and quiet. The staircase, lined with cypress trees and stone railings, is mostly empty.

The trade-off
Travelling outside the summer peak inevitably comes with compromises. Some seasonal businesses close for part of the year, particularly beach clubs, nightlife venues and restaurants that depend heavily on summer tourism. While Mediterranean destinations remain milder than much of northern Europe, daytime temperatures typically hover between 15 and 20 degrees Celsius, while evenings can dip into single digits. The sea is rarely warm enough for swimming, and shorter daylight hours limit the time available for sightseeing.

But when the crowds leave, cities begin to feel less like stage sets designed for tourism and more like places where people actually live. The key to enjoying Europe might not be in finding hidden places. More often, it is about picking the right time to visit.

Telugu

A bold musical fantasy



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At a time when Telugu cinema seems trapped in the pursuit of pan-Indian ambitions, with big-budget productions often resting on weakly written stories, *Sing Geetham* is a refreshing departure. Directed by 94-year-old filmmaker Singeetham Srinivasa Rao, it serves as a timely reminder that the industry can still take leaps of faith and offer audiences something new. The story reflects on the futility of human greed while reinforcing the need to live in harmony with Nature. Its musical fantasy-drama format springs from childlike innocence and an audacity to defy stale box-office formulas. Bringing wings to Rao’s 40-year-old dream project is a talented cast and crew, with music composer Devi Sri Prasad serving as the film’s backbone.

C Ankur’s cinematography frames the arid landscape as one of the film’s key characters as Pratap (newcomer Ayaan) approaches the fictional village of Kuberapuram. The setting feels almost dystopian. A lone tree offers shelter to villagers and passersby in the dusty mining settlement. As if from a children’s fairytale, Gauri (newcomer Ahilya) emerges from a cosy abode within the tree. As its name suggests, the village is rich in gold, and its mines are coveted by local and international interests alike. As profiteers eye expansion, the tree comes under threat.

The conversation around the promise of wealth and development, and why a tree should not stand in the way, immediately draws parallels to urban realities. In Hyderabad, debates continue over trees lining the KBR National Park being felled for flyovers. Similar concerns echo across India as green cover gives way to infrastructure projects. A film tackling such a subject could easily become preachy and dull. Instead, the musical fantasy format gives it a fresh spin, making it entertaining and engaging.

The transition depicting how the village is cursed, leaving its people unable to speak and forced to communicate through song, is a joy to watch. As the bewildered villagers wake up to their new reality and the catchy “Emayindi emayindi...” begins to play amid cheers in the theatre, it is hard not to admire Rao’s ingenuity

Much of the credit goes to the actors, young and old, who sing every line of dialogue throughout the film. Ayaan and Ahilya are terrific finds, bringing innocence, warmth and vulnerability to their roles. The real surprise comes from the many child actors, who deliver their sing-song dialogue with remarkable ease.

The story touches on several themes, from faith to humanity’s tendency to brand someone as a bad omen. By the end of *Sing Geetham*, I found myself wondering how the team pulled it off. Much like generations of cinema lovers continue to marvel at how Rao brought so many of his seemingly impossible ideas to life. It is no surprise that he remains celebrated, or that his films continue to endure.

Sing Geetham is currently running in theatres



Imtiaz Ali’s love story for the ages

Anchored by Naseeruddin Shah, Imtiaz Ali crafts a deeply evocative narrative that feels like a collective ache for human connection and healing in fractured times

Hindi

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A sweeping, bittersweet examination of displacement, *Main Vaapas Aaunga* is a timely, intimate, poetic character study about how geopolitical lines permanently alter the trajectory of human hearts. Imtiaz Ali’s filmography is built around characters who travel in search of their souls. Here, he evolves from his road movies and, together with co-writer Nayanika Mehtani, grounds this obsession in the tragedy of Partition, turning his lens toward the refugee crisis.

As always, Imtiaz steers clear of the macro-level politics. He treats Partition not as a grand battlefield, but as a spiritual wound. Unlike movies that use 1947 to fuel aggressive nationalist sentiments, the film reminds one of the sensitive, humanistic storytelling of Deepa Mehta’s *Earth* and Chandraprakash Dwivedi’s *Pinjar*, where the antagonist is not a specific community; it is the chaotic, unfeeling mechanics of history itself. By stripping the rioters of their specific religious identities and comparing them to an alien entity, the script shifts the focus from a familiar, polarising ‘us vs. them’ battle to a broader, existential commentary on the madness of violence and mocks the mechanics of hate.

The story revolves around an elderly man named Keenu (Naseeruddin Shah) who is severely ill and on his deathbed after suffering a debilitating stroke. Despite his physical paralysis and failing health, Keenu refuses to let go of life. He remains psychologically trapped in the past, constantly repeating that he must return to his ancestral home in Sargodha, now in Pakistan. In the lexicon of Partition poetry, Sargodha is not just a geographical city on a map.

Keenu’s grandson, Nirvair, (Diljit Dosanjh), who is struggling with his own migrant status in London, steps in as his caregiver. Through the elderly man’s slurred speech, sudden emotional outbursts, and fractured recollections,

Main Vaapas Aaunga

Director: Imtiaz Ali

Cast: Naseeruddin Shah, Diljit Dosanjh, Vadang Raina, Sharvari Wagh, Rajat Kapoor, Vinod Nagpal, Manish Chaudhuri

Storyline: A tech professional travels to Pakistan to fulfill the final wish of his grandfather who has dementia.



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which also inject a surreal, light-hearted charm that keeps the overarching tragedy from becoming utterly suffocating, the grandson pieces together a 78-year-old secret that the family had buried for generations.

Imtiaz acknowledges the work of The Partition Museum in Amritsar as the film flashes back to undivided Punjab, where a younger, more vibrant Keenu (Vedang Raina) falls passionately in love with Jia (Sharvari Wagh). Their beautiful, old-world courtship – defined by stolen glances, playful conversations, and a promise to always stay together – is violently interrupted by the Radcliffe Line. Keenu is forced to cross into India, carrying nothing but a lifelong promise that he would eventually return to her, a vow that consumes his entire life.

Jia and Keenu live up to Kabir’s credo, “*Haman hai ishq mastana, haman ko hoshiyari kya*” (We are intoxicated by love, what use do we have for worldly cleverness?), beautifully composed by AR Rahman. Imtiaz invokes Premchand’s moving fable, *Duniya Ka Sabse Anmol Ratan*, on what constitutes the ultimate sacrifice for freedom and love, and weaves it into his Partition narrative, turning a physical border crisis into a spiritual and philosophical quest. While Premchand’s story focused on nationalistic martyrdom, Ali subverts it to suggest that the most precious thing in the world is the teardrop of a refugee forced to leave their home, or the unwavering memory of an early youth romance that outlives decades of political separation.

Along the way, it questions the older generation’s decision to suppress their historical trauma and drink the poison of Partition in silence. It was meant to be an act of generational protection, but the film shows that trauma cannot be safely buried; it simply mutates. By leaving the history unaddressed, the silence itself becomes a toxic inheritance that leaves the younger generation completely unequipped to face modern-day prejudice.

The creative synergy between Shah and Imtiaz lends the thought a powerful emotional heartbeat. It marks an intersection where the veteran actor’s charming restraint meets the filmmaker’s signature poetic obsession with longing

and memories. The film works as a brilliant reclamation of Shah’s dramatic range as his performance transforms what could have been a standard framing device into a profound meditation on old age and lingering grief that tears you up. He reaches out from the deathbed, as if he will literally pull us into the screen with the sheer, unbridled force of his gaze.

At the same time, with stroke diagnoses becoming common and at times a burden for family members, Shah’s soul-stirring turn provides a bridge of empathy, allowing the audience to truly comprehend the silent, frustrating physical and emotional battles our own loved ones endure. As a commitment-phobic tech professional, Diljit serves as a literal surrogate for the modern audience.

Vedang Raina’s performance as the young Keenu suffers from a disconnect in character continuity. The young actor is sincere, a little too earnest, but he struggles to project the inherent gravitas or enigmatic charm needed to make the audience believe this boy will eventually evolve into Naseeruddin Shah’s weathered protagonist. Weeks before turning into *Alpha*, Sharvari channels the sassy eloquence and playful energy of the classic Imtiaz Ali heroine in a cinematic world guided by Rahman’s melodies and Irshad Kamil’s poetry.

Rahman is shifting his musical axis, fusing his global, synth-heavy soundscape with the raw, untamed heartbeat of Punjab. It is not an easy marriage and at times gives a sense of desperation to fit in, but the friction between Rahman’s clinical precision and Punjab’s bleeding heart is precisely where the magic happens.

Like Diljit’s performance, the film too occasionally trades subtlety for overt messaging; however, though this transparency or flatness irks a bit, after a point, it feels less like a narrative flaw and more like a deliberate, urgent response to our fractured times. In an era dominated by calculated outrage, the film functions as a vital cinematic antidote to rage-baiting, swapping polarising narratives for an empathetic, unifying, and healing prayer.

Main Vaapas Aaunga is currently running in theatres

A narrative vacuum

Hindi

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An economic thriller that utilises the textures of India’s Balance of Payments crisis of 1991 to deliver a message on state power, centralised authority, and the perceived liabilities of democratic noise, *Governor: The Silent Saviour* is yet another example of how history is being instrumentalised on screen today. It is not just looking back to understand the crippling economic impact of the Gulf War in 1991; it is looking back to legitimise the governance model of 2026.

Anchored by a restrained performance by Manoj Bajpayee as A. Ramanan, heavily based on former Reserve Bank of India Governor S. Venkitaramanan, the film, on the surface, attempts the rare cinematic feat of turning dry fiscal policy into a high-stakes commercial narrative. It looks beyond the typical uniform-wearing patriot guarding the



nation’s physical borders to focus on patriotism that stems from within the system to honour the collective, quiet desk-bound bureaucrats, who worked relentlessly behind closed doors to draft the economic turnaround when the country was on the brink of bankruptcy.

Structured as a fictionalised but idealised tribute to Venkitaramanan, where the narrative positions him as a pragmatic realist who took India forward from the dying breath of Nehruvian socialism to free market highway, the movie makes the

complex macroeconomic concepts accessible and emotionally engaging for a mainstream audience by bringing in common man and housewife logic and sentiments to make big-ticket decisions like mortgaging gold reserves to secure loans.

However, in the process, *Governor* falls squarely into the trap of reductionism, flattening a complex structural crisis into a simplistic, black-and-white melodrama, transforming a highly collaborative economic triumph into

the legend of a single silent saviour. Of course, because of the rapid, chaotic changes in the Union Government, it fell entirely upon Venkitaramanan to act as a solitary crusader flying across the world to raise the resources that prevented an international default.

But, marginalising key figures like Manmohan Singh and Subramanian Swamy diminishes the role of Chandra Shekhar and Yashwant Sinha, and simplifying C. Rangarajan’s (Noshad Mohamed Kunju is efficient as the sounding board) contribution feels like a selective erasure to present Venkitaramanan as the sole author of the blueprint of reforms that changed the course of the Indian economy.

More importantly, right from the first sequence, the film captures a historic economic crisis through a modern, national security-style lens. It subtly yet distinctively builds a narrative that subordinates democratic dissent and freedom of speech to state survival. It portrays an inquisitive press, depicted by an unusually wide-eyed Adah Sharma, almost as a liability.

When it paints the political

executive of the 1990s as a fractured, loud, and incompetent democracy and contrasts the noise of politicians with the quiet resolve of a single bureaucrat, it feeds directly into the modern populist yearning for an all-powerful executive who can bypass traditional institutional checks, balances, and public debates to get the job done. In such a

Governor: The Silent Saviour

Director: Chinmay D Mandlekar

Cast: Manoj Bajpayee, Noshad Mohamed Kunju, Adah Sharma, Madhoo, Paritosh Sand

Storyline: Set during the Balance of Payments crisis of 1991, the film follows RBI Governor A. Ramanan’s effort to prevent a national debt default by mortgaging gold reserves to secure loans.

scenario, a personal punchline, ‘fathers never fail,’ sounds politically loaded.

In terms of storytelling, after a point, director Chinmay Mandlekar, loses trust in the procedural realism of the story and the inherent tension in the economic crisis and switches to the ticking-clock anxiety of the gold airlift, complete with dramatic music, sweeping shots of trucks moving in the dead of night, and airport runway standoffs. If it feels lazy, the production design with full stops at the end of newspaper headlines shatters the cinematic illusion.

Bajpayee effortlessly commands the screen, but a weak supporting cast ensures that no other character can challenge his narrative authority. There are no complex, layered debates or intellectual stalemates in the script. In this vacuum, even Bajpayee’s performance stops feeling organic and starts looking like an exhibition of acting.

Governor is currently running in theatres

Disclosure Day

Director: Steven Spielberg

Cast: Emily Blunt, Josh O'Connor, Colin Firth, Eve Hewson, Colman Domingo

Storyline: A meteorologist and a cybersecurity expert find themselves at the centre of a movement to expose the government's cover-up of extraterrestrial secrets



Close encounter with wonder

English

Ayaan Paul Chowdhury

For about half a century, Steven Spielberg's cinema has taught audiences how to look up. Since his very first close encounter back in 1977 at Devil's Tower, Wyoming, the veteran auteur has repeatedly turned to the stars in search of something profoundly terrestrial. At 79, Spielberg is still making films in an industry shaped by his own successes, but the remarkable thing is that this beloved unc has still got the sauce. Even now, he grasps that intangible something many contemporary event

movies seem to have forgotten: that cinema is at its most powerful when a room full of strangers briefly share the same wide-eyed astonishment. *Disclosure Day* opens in the middle of a crisis. Josh O'Connor plays Daniel Kellner, a cybersecurity expert employed by WARDEX, a secretive contractor that has concealed evidence of alien contact dating back to the infamous Roswell Incident. After stealing classified archives and an extraterrestrial device, Daniel becomes a fugitive pursued by WARDEX director Noah Scanlon (Colin Firth), who is convinced that secrecy serves civilisation. Across Missouri, television meteorologist Margaret Fairchild (Emily Blunt) suddenly acquires inexplicable abilities,

speaking unfamiliar languages, perceiving strangers' memories through eye contact, and emitting uncanny guttural gibberish during a live broadcast. Spielberg constructs these parallel narratives as converging roads. The premise carries obvious echoes of post-Snowden whistleblower culture and decades of UFO conspiracy discourse. Yet Spielberg's interest lies elsewhere because alien revelation serves as an instrument for him to examine emotional distance. The writing repeatedly gestures to how humanity has been severed from community, separated by gulfs larger than interstellar space. What makes *Disclosure Day* feel expectedly rejuvenated is Spielberg's evergreen craftsmanship. Reuniting with cinematographer Janusz Kaminski, Spielberg once again proves that he remains perhaps Hollywood's greatest cartographer of cinematic

space. The ensemble understands the assignment, though the film ultimately belongs to Emily Blunt. If *Disclosure Day* stumbles, it does so in the places where Spielberg's faith in humanity brushes with the historical record of the past fifteen years. The film hammers home the point that releasing proof of alien life would fundamentally reorder civilisation, even as the world it depicts is already sleepwalking through nuclear brinkmanship and institutional collapse. All that said, Spielberg remains one of cinema's last great humanists, stubbornly insisting that looking toward the stars might teach us how to better inhabit the Earth. For anyone who grew up on his films, this is essential late-period Spielberg, and a jolly good time at the movies.

Disclosure Day is currently running in theatres

Snippets



Subhas Chandra Bose biopic announced: Aryan Shyam to lead

Gemini Film Circuit has officially announced a new biographical feature film based on the life of Subhas Chandra Bose, one of India's most influential freedom fighters and nationalist leaders. The upcoming historical drama will star Aryan Shyam in the lead role, with filmmaker Anand V Prasad attached to direct. The project aims to present a sweeping account of Bose's life, tracing his contributions to India's independence movement and his enduring impact on the nation's history. The film is being produced by Gemini Film Circuit, with Peru Tulasi Palani Vel serving as executive producer. Pre-production is currently underway, while principal photography is scheduled to begin later this year.



24 Jump Street in development at Sony

Sony Pictures is officially developing *24 Jump Street*, reviving one of the studio's most successful comedy franchises with Jonah Hill, Channing Tatum, and Ice Cube in talks to return. The project will be directed by Rodney Rothman, who is also co-writing the screenplay alongside Hill and Meghan Malloy. While story details remain under wraps, the sequel marks the first major movement on the franchise since *22 Jump Street* released in 2014. Phil Lord and Christopher Miller, who directed both *21 Jump Street* and *22 Jump Street*, will return as producers.



Prithviraj, Manju Warrier to star in Karan Johar's Malayalam debut

Malayalam filmmaker Rahul Sadasivan has announced his new project, *Odiyan: The Age of Illusion*, which also marks the entry of Karan Johar's Dharma Productions into Malayalam. The project, starring Prithviraj Sukumaran and Manju Warrier, is co-produced by Prithviraj Productions. Rahul is thus adding yet another project to his oeuvre of horror movies – *Bhoothakalam*, *Bramayugam*, and *Dies Irae*. In *Odiyan*, he will be taking up the popular myth of the Odiyan, known as nocturnal beings and shape-shifters. The stories about Odiyan are part of Kerala's regional folklore during the 19th century. The film is said to be exploring one such tale of how an Odiyan's fury falls upon a household.



Horrors of the Internet age

By transforming one of the Internet's most enduring urban legends into a fever dream of memory and nostalgia, Kane Parsons dreamcore horror is pure liminal intoxication

English

Ayaan Paul Chowdhury

The case of Kane Parsons is a curious one. He belongs to the first generation of filmmakers whose artistic education involved internet culture, videogame lore, analogue horror, and the endless well of knowledge at the end of a satisfying YouTube rabbit-hole. Yet his imagination keeps circling ideas that predate the internet by decades, pointing towards more fundamental concerns involving space, memory or dreams, which enchanted and inspired cult genre voices like David Lynch, Andrei Tarkovsky and Stanley Kubrick. The 20-year-old filmmaker behind the eponymous viral YouTube series built his reputation creating found-footage horror shorts through Blender and Adobe After Effects while still in high school. Those videos transformed a creepypasta inspired by a 2019 4chan image of an empty yellow room into one of the most defining horror mythologies of the internet. His feature adaptation for A24 follows Clark, played by Chiwetel Ejiofor, a failed architect who now manages Cap'n Clark's Ottoman Empire, a struggling furniture showroom in California, in 1990. While investigating strange electrical faults in the store's basement, he discovers a porous wall that leads into an endless uncanny-valley labyrinth of liminal rooms. Parsons and production designer Danny Vermette conceive the notoriously inconceivable Backrooms as a world assembled from half-remembered instructions about reality. The ingenious set design finds countless ways to visualise the original mythology's notion of "noclipping" from reality, scattering glitched furniture and half-submerged domestic detritus throughout the maze, while the winding geometry often evokes an *Alice in Wonderland*-style descent into ever deeper layers of spatial absurdity. Piss-yellow lighting against the dull, lifeless officecore purgatory notwithstanding, Jeremy Cox's marvellous found-footage cinematography compounds the unease

Backrooms

Director: Kane Parsons

Cast: Chiwetel Ejiofor, Renate Reinsve, Mark Duplass, Finn Bennett, and Lukita Maxwell

Storyline: A furniture store owner discovers a dimension of seemingly endless liminal spaces accessed through the basement of the store

through compositions that constantly deny any semblance of spatial certainty. Even though I have yet to read *House of Leaves*, Mark Z. Danielewski's novel exerts such enormous influence over the r/liminalspace subreddit that its mythic presence feels like an unavoidable comparison to draw here. It's a useful allegory nonetheless, considering both liminal horrors are two of the most distinctly postmodern descendants of the Labyrinth of Daedalus, exacerbating the ancient terror of becoming physically lost with the far more contemporary anxiety of becoming epistemologically lost. It also feels surprisingly close to the anime concept of an isekai, a genre built around ordinary people crossing a threshold into another world governed by unfamiliar laws (the crucial difference, of course, being that this particular isekai offers no improbably devoted entourage of anime girls waiting to validate your existence). Quite the opposite, in fact. Parsons populates the Backrooms with a profound and almost suffocating loneliness. Clark initially approaches his discovery with the curiosity of an architect stumbling upon the greatest structural anomaly in human history, painstakingly sketching maps of and excitedly recounting his findings to his therapist, Renate Reinsve's Dr. Mary Kline. Ejiofor plays these early scenes with manic enthusiasm that gradually curdles into obsession as every expedition yields fresh impossibilities. The more time Clark spends attempting to understand the Backrooms, the less interested he becomes in maintaining a life outside them. In the final act, when Mary eventually ventures into the Backrooms in search of the missing Clark, Parsons attempts some potent, if slightly clunky, commentary about trauma and the subconscious mind. As Mary's own reckoning with the labyrinth forces her to confront memories involving her childhood home and her emotionally troubled mother, one striking sequence – involving a static shot descending through successive layers of the same house, each iteration growing progressively more abstract and detached from reality – felt telling. Here, Parsons nudges at the idea that the Backrooms are a sprawling manifestation of buried memories and psychic debris.

So is this Parson's critique of American excess and consumerist accumulation? Or a *Synecdoche, New York*-style metaphor for a mind slowly disappearing into itself? Both readings have enough evidence to sustain them, which is why I find them less interesting than the experience of inhabiting the film. There is a particular kind of art that resists intellectual dissection yet communicates with remarkable clarity on an emotional level, and the film does lose some of its potency whenever screenwriter Will Soodik attempts to convert sensation into explanation. But what made *Backrooms* register so viscerally for me was how nostalgic portions of it felt. Parsons understands the peculiar, wistful wavelength of early-2000s dreamcore so intuitively that many of the images carry the strange sensation of remembering something you never actually experienced. Many of those visions are also supplemented by the woozy, retro-digital synth score he co-composed with Edo Van Breemen, which evoked the melancholy of Minecraft in many ways. And that atmosphere suspended my disbelief entirely and immersed me so completely in Parsons' uncanny imagination that solving the riddle of the Backrooms became secondary to simply existing inside this glitching mausoleum for late-capitalist interiors. This may seem like an awful lot of analysis for a film whose lineage can ultimately be traced back to a photograph of an empty room, but the undeniably distinct hypnotic expansiveness of the complete Backrooms Experience™ hopefully justifies my indulgence. Horror periodically reinvents itself whenever a new generation discovers fresh visual vocabularies for old anxieties, and Parsons possesses a rare ability to translate the absurd and deeply unsettling mythology of the online world into a cinematic language that feels entirely his own. The internet, as it turns out, is a terrifying place. Even more so for unsupervised and unsuspecting teenagers intoxicated by its endless wonders, to accidentally no-clip into oblivion.

Backrooms is currently running in theatres